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The dark side of mentoring on pre-service language teachers' identity formation

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HIGHLIGHTS

- Student teachers construct multiple identities in teaching practicum.
- Their identities are influenced by their mentoring teachers.
- Negative mentoring can impede their identity formation.

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ABSTRACT

This research explores the identity construction of two pre-service language teachers through their interactions with school mentors and university supervisors during their teaching practicum. Informed by self-discrepancy theory and possible-selves theory, the findings demonstrate how negative mentoring dismantled the student teachers' ideal identities (e.g., "a communicative teacher" and "an active learner") and created different ought (e.g., "a follower") and feared (e.g., "a controlling teacher") identities, which impinged on their professional learning and growth. This study concludes with practical implications on how to promote the effectiveness of mentoring to facilitate pre-service teachers' learning to teach.

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1. Introduction

Learning to teach can generally be conceptualized as a complex and dynamic process of identity (re)construction that occurs in pre-service teachers' professional practice and social interactions (Kelly, 2006). Over the past decades, there is a surge of research interest on student teacher identity in both general education (e.g., Izadinia, 2013; Timoštšuk & Ugaste, 2010) and language education (e.g., Clarke, 2008; Trent, 2010). In particular, increasing attention has been paid to how pre-service language teachers enact and transform their professional identities during the teaching practicum (e.g., Izadinia, 2015; Trent, 2010). By conducting classroom observation and teaching and interacting with different others (e.g., mentoring teachers and students) in field schools, pre-service teachers can enhance their teaching knowledge and reflective abilities as well as construct and refine their professional identities (Lawson, Çakmak, Gündüz, & Busher, 2015). Thus, as Farrell (2008) states, the teaching practicum is "one of the most important aspects of a teacher education program for learner teachers" (p. 226).

While the teaching practicum might present pre-service language teachers with a wide array of professional experiences, at its heart lies the relationship between student teachers and their mentoring teachers (Izadinia, 2015). Specifically, how student teachers interact and learn with their school mentors and university supervisors can determine to a large extent the quality of their practicum learning and influence their professional identities (Timoštšuk & Ugaste, 2010). To date, in spite of the strong evidence indicating that effective mentoring can familiarize student teachers with the school reality and help them develop professional knowledge (Mena, García, Clarke, & Barkatsas, 2015), there is a paucity of research on how mentoring can influence the identity (trans)formation of student teachers during the teaching practicum (Izadinia, 2013). To fill this gap, the present study, informed by self-discrepancy theory (e.g., Higgins, 1987) and possible-selves theory (e.g., Markus & Nurius, 1986), examines two student teachers' identity formation in relation to the mentoring they received during their teaching practicum in China. This research particularly explores the negative learning experiences of the student teachers with their school mentors and university supervisors and how such

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experiences impinged on their identity construction. While previous studies have shed light on how mentoring can be successfully implemented to facilitate pre-service teachers' professional learning (e.g., Awaya et al., 2003; Mena et al., 2015), a focus on the dark side of mentoring (i.e., the negative influences of ineffective mentoring) can generate useful insights into the complexities and challenges involved in pre-service teachers' learning to teach. Such insights can provide practical implications for current teacher education programs on how to maximize the potential of mentoring in promoting the identity development of student teachers.

2. Literature review

2.1. Student teacher identity and mentoring

Teacher identity represents the ways teachers make sense of themselves and the images they present to others (Alsup, 2006; Sfard & Prusak, 2005). Characterized as fluid, multifaceted, and contextual, teachers' identities arise from the continuous interactions between their personal values and experiences and their embedded institutional and socio-cultural environment (Kelly, 2006). For pre-service teachers, their identities are strongly influenced by their social engagement with significant others in the complex and dynamic process of learning to teach (Izadinia, 2015). Specifically, university-based teacher educators and school mentors play pivotal roles in shaping and reshaping pre-service teachers' identities through mentoring (Koerner, Rust, & Baumgartner, 2002; Timoštšuk & Ugaste, 2010). According to Malderez (2001), mentoring refers to "the support given by one (usually more experienced) person for the growth and learning of another, and for their integration into and acceptance by a specific community" (p. 57). During the teaching practicum, school mentors can support student teachers in lesson planning and classroom teaching through daily communication and regular meetings (Mena et al., 2015). University mentors can also provide support by observing the classroom teaching of student teachers and giving critical feedback for their further improvement (Lawson et al., 2015). While mentoring can promote student teachers' teaching competence, it also plays a socializing role by helping them develop a contextualized awareness of the institutional norms and culture, which they may be subject to in the future (Gebhard, 2009; Hobson, 2002). Therefore, effective mentoring can exert a transformative influence on pre-service teachers' professional learning and identity development (Izadinia, 2013). As shown in Izadinia (2015) study, the student teachers attributed their professional identity development to their school mentors' careful guidance characterized by academic and emotional support, mutual trust, and open communication. Similar findings were reported by Tsui and Law (2007), who explored how university teacher educators and school mentors formed a collaborative relationship to help student teachers develop their pedagogical reasoning and construct their identities as autonomous and flexible English teachers.

To date, while there is no lack of evidence on the positive outcomes of student teachers' learning to teach in teacher identity literature, little has been said about the challenges and complexities in student teachers' identity formation (Izadinia, 2013). In particular, although some studies (Boz & Boz, 2006; Ong'ondo & Borg, 2011) have pointed out the potential challenges involved in mentoring (e.g., unbalanced power relations between mentors and mentees) and their negative impact on student teachers' learning (e.g., their loss of self-autonomy), research on how ineffective mentoring may affect pre-service teachers' identity development is limited. To account for the intricate and complex nature of student teachers' identity formation, this study draws on self-discrepancy theory (Higgins, 1987) and possible-selves theory (Markus & Nurius, 1986) to explore the various identities that student teachers construct and reconstruct through their interactions with university teacher educators and school mentors during the teaching practicum and how the congruence and conflicts between their identities might influence their professional growth as language teachers.

2.2. Self-discrepancy theory and possible-selves theory

Developed from educational psychology, self-discrepancy theory (Higgins, 1987, 1989) and possible-selves theory (Markus & Nurius, 1986; Markus & Wurf, 1987) have been widely employed to examine the motivations, affect, and behaviors of teachers in different educational contexts (e.g., Gao & Xu, 2014; Kubanyiova, 2009). These two interrelated theories generally propose that the notion of "self-concept" i.e., "the summary of the individual's self-knowledge related to how the person views him/herself" (Dörnyei, 2009, p. 11), can function as an interpretive framework for individuals to evaluate themselves and others, as well as to plan and adjust their current and future behavior (Higgins, 1987; Markus & Nurius, 1986). In particular, Higgins (1987) conceptualizes three domains of the self: "the actual self" (i.e., the attributes individuals are believed to actually possess), "the ideal self" (i.e., the attributes individuals ideally like to possess), and "the ought self" (i.e., the attributes individuals are supposed to possess as a result of certain duties and responsibilities). Markus and Nurius (1986), informed by the future-oriented dimension of self-concept (Dörnyei, 2009), further argue that the construction of self-concept involves using imagination and reflection to create a set of hoped-for (i.e., ideal selves that people would like to become) and feared selves (i.e., selves people are afraid of becoming), which serve as incentives for people's future actions (Markus & Wurf, 1987). Moreover, the two theories emphasize that the different selves (i.e., the actual, ought, ideal/hoped-for, and feared) may align and/or contradict each other because of the ongoing interaction between individuals' personal values and aspirations as well as the institutional and socio-cultural influences (Oyserman, 2001). Their congruence and disparity can thus exert powerful influences on individuals' cognitive learning, motivation change, and personal growth (Higgins, 1989).

In fact, the different selves (i.e., actual, ought, ideal/hoped-for, and feared) proposed by self-discrepancy theory (Higgins, 1987, 1989) and possible-selves theory (Markus & Nurius, 1986) resonate with current teacher education literature (Beauchamp & Thomas, 2009; Izadinia, 2013), which underscores the *multi-faceted, contextual,* and *imagined* nature of teacher identity. As exhibited in existing studies (e.g., Beijaard, Meijer, & Verloop, 2004), teachers can construct a repertoire of identities through their engagement in teaching, their social interactions with different others, and their imagining about the future. For instance, while teachers aspire to act as "change agents" in innovating classroom teaching ("the ideal identity"), they may be confined by the rigid school policy and work as a "curriculum follower" ("the ought-to identity") in their professional contexts (Lee, 2013). For student teachers, despite their willingness to view themselves as "facilitators" of student learning ("the ideal identity"), their limited practical experience and teaching competence may position them as "novices" ("the actual identity") who may be unable to meet the learning needs of their students (Flores & Day, 2006). Therefore, the disparity between the different identities can induce negative emotions and impede teachers' professional development (Timoštšuk & Ugaste, 2010). However, by exercising their self-agency, i.e., the individual's ability to reflect on their professional actions and seek possible change within institutional and social constraints (Lasky, 2005; Sexton, 2008), teachers may turn their identity conflicts into "the driving forces" (Gao & Xu, 2014, p. 153) in facilitating their continuous learning and career pursuit.

This research examines student teachers' identity formation in relation to the mentoring they received from the university teacher educators and school mentors in the teaching practicum. Specifically, by looking into the student teachers' multiple identities (i.e., the actual, ought, ideal, and feared) as well as their alignment and contradictions, this study can add to our knowledge of the complex, dynamic, and contested process of learning to teach (Clarke, 2008). One central question guides this research: *How did the student teachers construct their identities in relation to the mentoring they received during the teaching practicum*?

3. The study

3.1. Research context and participants

The present study is part of a larger research project that explores student teachers' professional learning through the teacher education program in a normal university in China. At the beginning of the project, invitations for research participation were sent to all Year-4 pre-service language teachers (a total of 70) in the program. Given the requirement of the study (i.e., the participants would participate in in-depth interviews and allow the researcher to conduct field observation in the practicum schools), five student teachers responded to my invitation and agreed to take part in the research on a voluntary basis. While the project explores the identity (re)construction of the five participants by gathering data from interviews, field observation, and their reflective journals, this paper reports on the professional experiences of two research participants, Ming and Yang (pseudonyms are used), owing to their negative mentoring experiences with an unfavorable influence on their identity development during the teaching practicum.

The four-year pre-service program, which includes teacher education coursework and teaching practicum, aims to develop qualified language teachers for primary and secondary teaching. In the first three years, the program provides student teachers with a range of language proficiency courses (e.g., Intensive Reading and Spoken English) and language teacher education courses (e.g., Language Teaching Methodology and Curriculum and Syllabus Design) to promote their language competence and help them build a solid knowledge foundation about language teaching and learning. In the fourth year, student teachers are assigned to different local schools for a 10-week teaching practicum, where they can engage in classroom teaching and link theories with practice. According to the program arrangement, each student teacher is assigned a university supervisor (i.e., a teacher educator in the university program) and a school mentor (i.e., a serving teacher from the field school) to facilitate his/her practical learning. Specifically, the school mentor takes the major responsibility for guiding, supporting, and evaluating the student teacher's learning, whereas the university supervisor pays regular visits to the practicum school (e.g., for classroom observation and post-lesson reflection) and provides necessary support in collaboration with the school mentor.

The two participants, namely, Ming and Yang, one male and one female, were from the same cohort of pre-service language teachers. They had completed all the required teacher education courses in the first three years of the program. On the fourth year, Ming was assigned to a suburban junior high school with students of relatively weak academic performance. He was under the guidance of an experienced female English teacher who was approaching retirement. In her Grade 8 class with 50 students, the mentor not only taught English, but also served as head teacher who was responsible for classroom management and student affairs. Yang conducted her teaching practicum in an urban senior high school with a good reputation for its competent teachers and excellent students. Her mentor was a female English teacher with 20 years of teaching experience. Similar to Ming's mentor, she also taught English and worked as head teacher in a Grade 11 class with 40 students. As required by the program, two different university supervisors (i.e., language teacher educators working in the program) were assigned to Ming and Yang respectively to provide necessary support through school visits and informal communication (i.e., emails and phone calls).

At the time of the study, I worked as an assistant university supervisor in the pre-service teacher education program. My role helped me gain full access to the field schools for data collection, though I was not directly assigned to be the university supervisor for Ming or Yang. Before the study commenced, ethical approval was obtained from the university, the field schools, and the two participants.

3.2. Data collection

The data were collected from multiple sources, including in-depth interviews, field observation, and the personal reflections of the participants.

First, four rounds of semi-structured interviews were conducted during the teaching practicum to explore the student teachers' "experiences, memories, and their developing professional selves" (Alsup, 2006, p. 192), with particular attention paid to their interactions with the university teacher educators and school mentors in the practicum. The first interview focused on the previous learning of the participants in the teacher education coursework, their perceptions of language teaching, and their self-understanding as language teachers. The participants were also asked to share their expectations about their school mentors and their learning objectives in the teaching practicum. The second and third interviews, which were respectively conducted on the fourth and eighth week of the practicum, explored the participants' actual learning and identity formation in the field schools. In particular, the student teachers were asked to describe their professional engagement and social interactions with the school mentors and university supervisors, along with their possible influence on the participants' self-perceptions as language teachers. In the last interview, which was carried out at the end of the program, the participants were guided to reflect on their entire practicum experiences and depict their identity conflicts and change (if any), specifically with regard to the mentoring they received in the schools. In all the interviews, I engaged in meaning construction with the participants and guided them in sharing critical stories (especially those involving the school mentors and/or university supervisors) that were influential in shaping their professional identities (Sfard & Prusak, 2005). The interviews were audio-recorded and conducted in Chinese, because the two participants felt at ease sharing their personal experiences and reflections through their mother tongue. All the interviews were further transcribed by the researcher and sent back to the participants for checking and clarification.

Field observation was conducted to examine how the participants engaged in practical learning and social interactions, which could serve as an important source of their identity formation (Kelly, 2006). Particularly, upon negotiation with the participants, I paid visits to the two schools twice a week. These visits allowed me to observe how they planned their lessons and conducted classroom teaching, as well as how they interacted with the school mentors and/or university supervisors. In the end, a total of three lessons (each lasting 45 min) were observed and video-recorded for each participant. Also, I observed and audio-recorded[1] three joint discussion sessions (e.g., lesson plan meeting) between Ming and

[1] The classroom teaching was video-recorded with the consent of the participants and the students, while the joint discussion sessions were audio-recorded as required by the school mentors and university supervisors.

his school mentor and/or university supervisor, whereas for Yang I observed and audio-recorded seven discussion sessions. Each of the discussion sessions ranged from 20 to 30 min. During my field observation, I took notes to capture the professional practice and interactions of the participants. After leaving the school, I immediately summarized and enriched my notes while the experience was still fresh in my mind. Detailed information of the field observation is provided in Table 1.

Apart from interviews and field observation, the participants' personal reflections (required by the study) were also collected. During the practicum, the student teachers kept a weekly journal (in Chinese), where they recorded their personal experiences and interactions with different people (including their school mentor and university supervisor) and shared their feelings and thoughts. Thus, their personal reflections could triangulate and enrich the research data and shed light on the research question.

3.3. Data analysis

All the data were analyzed following a systematic qualitative inductive approach (Strauss & Corbin, 1998) and the relevant transcripts were subsequently translated into English by the researcher and checked by the participants (who were English majors) to avoid the potential loss of meaning in the translation process.

First, the interview transcripts were carefully reviewed to identify the various identities the participants enacted in the practicum in relation to their mentoring experiences. Special attention was paid to the "indigenous concepts" (Patton, 2002, p. 454) used by the participants in describing themselves and their learning with the school mentors and university supervisors. As a result, a range of identity themes emerged, including "a caring and supportive teacher", "a follower", "an accomplice", "a puppet", "an outsider", "a secretary", and "a spokesman". All the identity themes were further compared, integrated, and modified by referring to the theoretical framework, i.e., self-discrepancy theory (Higgins, 1987) and possible-selves theory (Markus & Nurius, 1986), resulting in an overall classification of all the identities under four major categories (i.e., "actual identity", "ideal identity", "ought identity", and "feared identity") with their congruence and disparity identified.

As for the field observation data, the video and audio recordings were reviewed and analyzed together with the observation notes from the theoretical perspectives. A series of significant episodes was then identified, shedding light on the participants' identities arising from their interactions with their school mentors and university supervisors in the practicum. For example, in Yang's classroom teaching, she was interrupted by the mentor who asked her to skip the questions and move on to the vocabulary exercises. The interruption gave rise to Yang's identity as a "spokesman" of the mentor in her own teaching. All the identified episodes were transcribed and shared with the participants for their further comments. As for the weekly journals of the participants, these were constantly revisited to triangulate with the other data sources. In order to enhance the trustworthiness of the study, the participants were invited to make comments on the research findings, which they both agreed with.

4. Research findings

In this section, I present the research findings case by case to provide a detailed and analytical account of the participants' identity construction in relation to the mentoring they received during the practicum.

4.1. Ming

Before the teaching practicum, Ming constructed an ideal teacher identity, i.e., "a caring and supportive teacher who can cater to students' needs and interests". This identity was partly influenced by his previous high school teacher and partly derived from his professional learning in the teacher education coursework:

> *My high school head teacher was caring and kind and he gave students a lot of guidance and encouragement…I wish I can become a teacher like him in the future. (Interview 1)*

> *From the courses I took, I understand learners will have different learning styles and their motivations and attitudes also vary. So we need to be sensitive to students' learning needs and interests. (Interview 1)*

To live out his ideal identity in his teaching practicum, Ming expressed his expectations for his future school mentor:

> *I hope to have a nice mentor who will give me opportunities to experiment with new ideas. I will try to be active in my learning and I hope the mentor can help me learn how to use the communicative approach in language teaching. (Interview 1)*

By constructing his projected image of a "nice mentor," Ming developed his own ideal identity as an "active learner" with a need for both autonomy and guidance in his learning to teach.

At the beginning of the teaching practicum, Ming felt welcomed by the school mentor who directly involved him in student management and some basic teaching duties, such as supervising students' individual study and checking their assignments. While such work seemed "trivial" with no direct relation to language teaching,

Table 1
Field observation of the participants.

Participants	Classroom teaching	Joint discussion
Ming	3 lessons	2 lesson planning meetings (between Ming and the school mentor) 1 post-lesson conference (between Ming, the school mentor, and the university supervisor)
Yang	3 lessons	3 lesson planning meetings (between Yang and the school mentor) 3 post-lesson conferences (between Yang and the school mentor) 1 post-lesson conference (between Yang and the university supervisor)

Ming felt it demonstrated the mentor's trust in him. For him, such duties could benefit his ongoing practice and learning in the field (Interview 2). However, Ming soon discovered that the mentor employed a traditional teaching approach with a strong emphasis on grammar exercise and rote learning. Such a teaching style largely contradicted Ming's personal beliefs about language teaching:

> *My mentor's teaching is all about grammar and vocabulary. I feel surprised and a bit disappointed because I think language teaching should be interactive, authentic, and student-centered. (Interview 1)*

In terms of student management, as the head teacher, the mentor adopted a high-handed approach, which exerted a negative influence on the learning motivations of students. As Ming shared in his personal reflection:

> *It is shocking to find out how busy the students are in the class. From Monday to Friday, they need to go to the classroom at 7:00 AM to do morning reading. There is also an individual study every night from 7:00 PM to 9:00 PM. But the mentor requires the students to start early at 6:00 PM. The mentor told me the students are naughty and they need more time to study in order to get a good exam result…But some students told me they don't like English. They think it is difficult and boring. (Interview 4)*

The mentor's traditional teaching style and strong control on students posed threats to Ming's ideal identity as a "caring and supportive language teacher", especially when he was required by the mentor to work as her "assistant" during the practicum:

> *I feel the mentor treats me as an assistant to help her control the students. For example, she asked me to "spy" on the students and report to her who was misbehaving in other classes. I feel the classroom is like a "prison": the students are "prisoners" who are under the strict supervision of the mentor as "warden". (Weekly journal)*

By describing the mentor as a "warden" and the students as "prisoners", Ming expressed his unease about the negative learning atmosphere in the classroom. However, given his status as an "intern teacher" (i.e., his actual identity) in the field school, Ming felt unable to resist the mentor's requirement and served as the mentor's "assistant" in managing the students:

> *I think the school just expects us (student teachers) to follow school mentors' instructions during the teaching practicum. This is like an implicit law. So although I felt what the mentor did might not be right, I dared not say anything. (Interview 2)*

Given the "implicit law" derived from the low status of student teachers in the school, Ming became a "follower" (i.e., his ought identity) who had to obey the mentor's orders unconditionally (Weekly journal). This ought identity not only collided with the ideal identity ("an active teacher who needed autonomy and guidance") he had constructed before the teaching practicum, but it also brought him strong negative emotions (e.g., guilt) and led to a new identity as an "accomplice" of the mentor:

> *I was very guilty as I became the mentor's "accomplice" and deprived the students of the pleasure of language learning. I really became the opposite of what I wanted to become. (Weekly journal)*

Thus while Ming feared to become a controlling teacher (i.e., his feared identity), he nevertheless served as the mentor's "accomplice" (i.e., his actual identity) who deprived the students of the pleasure in language learning. The identity conflicts thus took a toll on his practical learning in the field:

> *I was frustrated because I was doing what I did not like on a daily basis and I could not say anything…I felt like there was nothing for me to learn. (Interview 4)*

In the fourth week, Ming started his own practical teaching according to the program arrangement. As a strong advocate of the communicative approach, Ming hoped he could implement this approach, which might "bring students a different learning experience and promote their learning interests" (Weekly journal). However, Ming's projected self-identity as a "communicative teacher" was overturned by the mentor who required him to adopt the traditional method in his practice. For instance, when Ming demonstrated his lesson plan with some communicative tasks, the mentor asked Ming to cut the interactive activities and focus on teaching the grammar rules, which were more important for examinations:

***School mentor**: I don't think you need to do the lead-in activity. It is time-consuming.*

***Ming**: Okay, but I think it might be useful if they (students) can have a discussion to talk about their travel experiences before I start the new unit?*

***School mentor**: Not really. Their English is not good, so even if you ask them to discuss, they may chat in Chinese. I suggest you teach the new words first. What do you think?*

***Ming:** Okay. (Field observation)*

Thus, while Ming desired for a certain degree of autonomy that could allow him to experiment with innovative ideas, he was confronted with a controlling mentor who placed a strict limit on what and how he should teach. His ought identity as a "follower" impeded the actualization of his ideal identity as a "language teacher who can cater to students' needs and interests". Instead, the experience turned him into a "traditional teacher" (i.e., his actual identity) in his professional practice. Therefore, Ming felt he became a "puppet" who was fully controlled by his mentor in classroom teaching:

> *I was like a puppet. Before the practicum, our university teachers said we should be reflective and learn with our mentors. But the reality is I do not have any autonomy in my own teaching. So how am I supposed to learn here? (Interview 3)*

As shown in the quote above, Ming's actual identity as a "puppet" contradicted his ought identity as a "teacher learner" advocated by the teacher education program. Give the different identity conflicts (i.e., "communicative teacher" versus "traditional teacher"; "follower"/"puppet" versus "teacher learner"), Ming felt "completely lost" in the field school (Weekly journal).

Overall, during the teaching practicum, Ming taught a total of eight lessons by himself. However, only one of them followed the communicative teaching approach that he preferred. In that particular lesson attended by the university supervisor, Ming was allowed to design and implement a range of interesting and interactive tasks to help students learn how to write a biography. After the lesson, Ming engaged in a post-lesson discussion with both the school mentor and university supervisor. As Ming

reflected:

I think the mentor allowed me to use the communicative approach in that lesson because she knew the university supervisor was going to visit me. So it was like a show...I just felt just like an actor in front of them. (Interview 3)

As indicated in the above quote, Ming's self-perception as an "actor" implied his disappointment in such a "show", which is of limited value to his professional growth as a language teacher. Although the university supervisor raised some questions and provided useful suggestions for improving this lesson (field observation), Ming could not integrate the comments of the supervisor into real practice, as he had to revert to the traditional method in the following lessons. When asked if he could share his situation with the university supervisor and ask for her help, Ming felt he did not want to "create any trouble or conflict", especially when the school mentor was in charge of his practicum assessment:

The mentor is responsible for my practicum assessment, and I do not want to get a bad result in the end…Also the university supervisors only visited me twice and observed one lesson. So I did not say much to her. What was the point? There was not much she could do given my situation. (Interview 4)

The high-stakes practicum assessment, coupled with limited involvement of the university supervisor, silenced Ming's voice and inhibited his self-agency to seek change in the constraining situation (Lasky, 2005). In order not to be labeled a "trouble maker" (i.e., his feared identity) and gain a negative assessment result, Ming had to internalize his ought identity as a "follower" and remain as the mentor's "assistant".

Looking back at the teaching practicum, Ming felt he developed a realistic understanding of language teachers' professional lives in school contexts, despite his lack of sufficient opportunities and guidance for practical learning. In particular, Ming referred to his mentor as a typical teacher who was subjected to the accountability culture and hierarchical system in her school:

The school put strong emphasis on students' exam results as it wanted to boost its reputation. So the teachers were all under great stress to promote students' exam performance. I guess the mentor was just trying to meet the institutional demands and survive in the school. (Interview 4)

While Ming showed understanding for the difficulties of his mentor, he claimed he "would not become a teacher like her who was controlling and exam-driven" (Weekly journal). Instead, stimulated by his feared identity (i.e., a teacher like his mentor) (Markus & Nurius, 1986), Ming expressed his determination to live out his ideal identity as a "caring and supportive teacher" who would not yield to a "tough and challenging reality":

My teaching practicum is like a "wake-up call" to me. It reminds me that the reality of teaching can be tough and challenging and, as a teacher, I need to be strong and competent to do what I think is right for my students. (Interview 4)

4.2. Yang

Yang shared similar beliefs with Ming about language teaching and learning before the teaching practicum. Influenced by her past student experiences and informed by her professional learning in the university coursework, she constructed an ideal identity as a "modern teacher" in implementing the communicative approach in her future practice:

I was a victim of the traditional approach. In my high school, I could not speak English at all. All I did were grammar exercises. After I entered the university, I improved my spoken abilities in the language courses where the teachers used the communicative approach. In the teacher education courses, I also learned about the rationale behind this approach. So in the future I will use it to help my students learn English for real communication. (Interview 1)

Given her lack of teaching experience, Yang was concerned about potential discipline problems in the classroom. Thus, she projected herself as an "apprentice" who could learn from her mentor about student management:

I see myself as an "apprentice" in the practicum. Actually, I am quite worried about classroom management. As a new teacher, will students respect me? How can I establish my credibility as a teacher? I hope my mentor can guide me to find answers to these questions. (Interview 1)

During the practicum, as opposed to Yang's expectations, her mentor turned out to be quite "distant" and "treated her like an outsider" (Interview 2). On her first day in the field school, while other student teachers were invited by their mentors to introduce themselves to the students, Yang was left alone in the staff office:

The mentor said there was no need to have a formal introduction as she had already told the students about me. But when I saw my peers go to their classes and say "Hello" to their students, I felt a bit rejected as an outsider. (Interview 2)

As the practicum progressed, Yang's identity as an "outsider" was further enhanced as the mentor gave her many assignments, such as preparing teaching materials and marking students' writing. These duties kept her working in the staff office and deprived her of opportunities to interact with students and engage in classroom management:

The mentor gave me a lot of work and told me that I did not need to go to the classroom except for lesson observation. I told my friends what I was doing in the school and they joked that I was like my mentor's secretary. I think they were totally right. (Weekly journal)

Given the "mechanical and dull assignments" and her limited interactions with students, Yang took on the identity as the mentor's "secretary" (i.e., her actual identity) as opposed to her ideal identity as an "apprentice" who could learn about student management under the mentor's guidance. The identity conflict brought much unease to Yang and exerted a negative impact on her learning:

What I did was just marking, typing, and making photocopies. It was so mechanical and dull...I felt quite depressed and lost here. (Interview 2)

Like Ming, Yang chose to keep quiet about her difficulties in the school and followed the instructions of her mentor. Her compliance could partly be attributed to her respect for her mentor as an authority figure in the school (Tan, 2012):

I think she is an expert in the school. She has been teaching English for many years and she knows her students and the school very

well. So I thought I need to respect her and do what she asks me to do. (Interview 4)

Yang's respect for authority thus turned her into a "follower" (i.e., her ought identity) who "listened to the mentor and fulfilled her requirement without questions" (Weekly journal).

In terms of language teaching, Yang's mentor was traditional and exam-driven with a primary focus on vocabulary teaching. As Yang described:

Because the students are competent, the mentor told me that there is no need to teach much about grammar. What they need is a large repertoire of vocabulary to help them perform well in reading and writing in exams. So she asked students to memorize a lot of vocabulary and do dictation in each lesson. (Interview 3)

The mentor required Yang to teach in the same style despite her strong inclination to follow the communicative approach. Similar to Ming's experience, Yang was "advised by the mentor to cut the interactive activities in her lesson plan and spend more time on teaching and assessing vocabulary" (Weekly journal). Also, in a lesson I observed, while Yang was asking some students about the meaning of some vocabulary and inviting them to construct sentences, the mentor who was sitting behind the class suddenly interrupted Yang's teaching and asked her to move on to the next activity (Field observation). Reflecting on this incident, Yang mentioned:

I felt quite embarrassed when the mentor directly asked me to stop and move on. After the lesson, she told me that students had already learned about the vocabulary, so I did not have to go through them again. Also she was worried that I could not finish all the activities in time. I felt a bit upset because the mentor did not see me as a teacher and she simply gave me orders in my classroom. (Interview 3)

As shown in the above example, the mentor not only prescribed what Yang taught, but she also exercised strict control on Yang's teaching style and pace. As a result, Yang found it challenging to actualize her ideal identity as a "communicative teacher" in her classroom practice. Instead, the identity of "spokesman" was imposed on her:

I am just a spokesman of the mentor. Whatever I did in the classroom had to be approved by her. It was like an unspoken rule between us. She kept asking me to rush the lesson and do more exercises. I did not see "me" in my own teaching. (Interview 3)

Due to the "unspoken rule" dictating the way she should interact with the mentor (as a "follower") and engage in teaching (as a "traditional teacher"), Yang became the mentor's "spokesman" (i.e., her ought identity) who followed her instructions without any autonomy in teaching (Interview 4). This situation could also be attributed to her isolated status in the school without a sense of belonging:

Even if students can memorize the vocabulary and complete the exercise, it does not mean they really master them. But I could not say anything. For the mentor, I am just an outsider of her class. I guess she just wants me to finish my teaching without creating any disturbance. (Weekly journal)

Although Yang doubted the effectiveness of the mentor's traditional approach, being an "outsider" not only confined her interactions with students, but also took away her sense of autonomy and further reinforced her identity as a "spokesman" of the mentor.

Different from Ming, Yang shared her problems with the university supervisor when she came to visit and conduct lesson observation. In the post-lesson meeting where the school mentor was absent, the university supervisor expressed her concerns about Yang's overt emphasis on language forms with limited attention to the communicative aspects of language learning. After listening to her constraining situation, the university supervisor encouraged Yang to talk to her mentor and modify her teaching:

The university supervisor encouraged me to bring in more interactive and authentic tasks. But how could I do it? You know I was afraid of my mentor. Sometimes she could be quite serious and authoritative. She had already told me to follow her teaching approach, so it was difficult to initiate any change. (Interview 4)

The above quote illustrates the contradiction between Yang's ought identity as a "communicative teacher" advocated by the university supervisor and her actual identity as a "traditional teacher" dictated by the school mentor. For Yang, the university supervisor only came to visit the school once without meeting the school mentor who had to attend a school meeting. Therefore, the university supervisor might not have fully understood the constraints Yang faced in the practicum. Although Yang thought the suggestions raised by the university supervisor were constructive, her hands were tied in the school context, where she lacked power and autonomy (Hobson, 2002).

However, on one occasion, Yang found that some students had trouble in their writing of argumentative essays. She realized that through mechanical drills, students merely remembered the grammatical rules and vocabulary instead of understanding the discourse features of argumentation. In the post-lesson meeting, Yang shared her observation with the mentor and suggested the genre-based approach she had learned from the university coursework (Field observation). Fortunately, the mentor took her suggestions and allowed her to try out some new activities in the next lesson, which proved to be a success:

The mentor thought my idea was just something that might help occasionally. But the tasks helped the students develop a better awareness of the essay structure…This lesson strengthened my faith in task-based approach… Maybe I cannot use this approach here, but I will try it out in my future school. (Interview 4)

Thus, when a practical problem emerged in the classroom, Yang tried to exercise her self-agency within the constraining context to facilitate students' language learning. This experience helped Yang strengthen her ideal identity as a "modern teacher". However, except for this lesson, Yang was still restricted to teaching in the traditional way, focusing primarily on vocabulary explanation and mechanical drills, which sustained her identity as a "traditional teacher" and "spokesman" during the teaching practicum.

Looking into the future, while Yang expressed her willingness to work as a "communicative teacher" (i.e., her ideal identity), she was worried that she might not able to embrace such an identity in her practice due to potential obstacles embedded in her work context:

So I am wondering whether the communicative approach will be accepted by my future colleagues and school leaders. If they all believe in the traditional approach, I might become an "odd person" who cannot fit in the school. I do not want to become isolated, but I do not want to become a mechanical teacher droning on grammar

and vocabulary either. It is quite a dilemma and I do not know what to do. (Weekly journal)

Based on her practicum experience and her active imagination about the future teaching (e.g., the exam-oriented system and the disapproval from her future colleagues and school leaders), Yang constructed two feared identities: "a mechanical teacher" who adopts the traditional approach and "an odd person" who might be isolated in her school. Given the lack of guidance from her school mentor and the limited involvement of her university supervisor, Yang was clueless on ways to resolve this identity conflict as reflected in her last statement: "It is quite a dilemma and I do not know what to do." In other words, Yang had to face this predicament by herself, which might negatively influence her identity development and continuous learning.

5. Discussion

Informed by self-discrepancy theory (Higgins, 1989) and possible-selves theory (Markus & Nurius, 1986), the present research demonstrates the dark side of mentoring on student teachers' learning to teach. Specifically, the findings show the congruence and disparity of the student teachers' different identities, which impinged on their professional learning during the teaching practicum. First, influenced by their previous learning experience and informed by the teacher education coursework in the pre-service program, the participants engaged in active imagination and enacted different ideal identities to guide their teaching and learning in the practicum (Beauchamp & Thomas, 2009; Higgins, 1989). For instance, Ming projected himself as a "supportive and caring teacher" and "active learner" who needed both autonomy and guidance, while Yang desired to become a "modern teacher" adopting the communicative approach and an "apprentice" who would learn about classroom management from the school mentor.

However, the participants encountered great challenges in achieving their ideal identities due to the negative influences of the school mentors (Boz & Boz, 2006). In Ming's case, although he was actively involved in student management, the mentor required him to take on the identity of an "assistant" who helped her monitor and control students. Despite his disagreement with the mentor's management style, which stifled students' learning motivation, Ming was forced to comply with the mentor's instructions due to his low status in the school, which positioned him as a "follower" (i.e., his ought identity). Working as an "assistant" and "follower" for the mentor led to his new identity as an "accomplice" (e.g., his actual identity), which overturned his ideal identity as a "supportive and caring teacher". Different from Ming's mentor who involved him in student management, Yang's mentor deprived her of opportunities to interact with students and engage in classroom management. Given that she was preoccupied with different assignments in the staff office, Yang's ideal identity as an "apprentice" who could learn from the mentor fell out of alignment with the school reality, where she was positioned as an "outsider" and "secretary." Similar to Ming, Yang took on the "follower" identity (i.e., her ought identity) prescribed by the mentor due to her respect for authority (i.e., her mentor). As a result, she experienced a strong sense of isolation in the school with a loss of learning motivation and direction.

Conflicts between the participants' ideal and ought identities were evident in their teaching practice, which was strictly controlled by the school mentors. As shown in the findings, Ming and Yang were unable to practice what they believed in language teaching and actualize their identities as "communicative teachers". Instead, they were forced by the mentors to take on identities as "traditional teachers" (i.e., their ought identities) with a heavy focus on mechanical exercise and rote learning. What's worse, the mentors not only dictated what Ming and Yang taught, but they also prescribed their teaching pace and style. In Yang's case, the mentor directly interrupted her classroom teaching and discredited her as a legitimate teacher in the school. Consequently, the participants took on new identities as "puppet" and "spokesman", which severely contradicted their ideal identities as a "teacher learner" with a need for autonomy and guidance (especially in Ming's case).

The study also indicates that the contradictions between the participants' ought identities could take a toll on their professional learning in the practicum. For instance, Ming described his frustrations in face of the clash between his identity as a "follower" (i.e., required by the school mentor) and a "teacher learner" (i.e., advocated by the teacher education program). In a similar vein, Yang was caught in a conflict between her identity as a "traditional teacher" demanded by the mentor and a "communicative teacher" emphasized by the university supervisor. Echoing previous studies (Flores & Day, 2006; Zeichner, 2010), the findings showcased the disconnections between the university coursework with a strong focus on academic theories and knowledge and the teaching practicum situated in complex school reality. Such disconnections might create conflicting demands for pre-service language teachers and impede their identity development (Trent, 2010).

Furthermore, while the participants attempted to construct positive images of what they would like to become (i.e., their ideal identities) in the future, they developed negative perceptions of the identity they wanted to avoid (i.e., their feared identities) due to the mentoring they received in the practicum (Kubanyiova, 2009; Markus & Wurf, 1987). In the current study, the feared identities of the student teachers served as a "double-edged sword," which influenced their professional learning and practice. On the one hand, the participants experienced strong negative feelings when they were forced to live out their feared identities during their practice. For instance, working as the "accomplice" of the mentor who adopted a high-handed approach in student management, Ming felt guilty because he became what he feared (i.e., a controlling teacher) in the practicum. The feared identities of the participants also curbed their sense of agency and constrained their prospective actions. After the practicum, Yang was at a loss about her future work because of the dilemma between her two feared identities, namely, "an odd person" isolated in school and "a mechanical teacher" adopting the traditional approach. On the other hand, the feared identities of the student teachers might be instrumental in guiding their ongoing practice and learning through critical reflections and active imagination about the future. Stimulated by his feared identity (i.e., a teacher like his mentor), Ming expressed his willingness to cope with potential obstacles in his future work and become "a caring and supportive teacher" he aspired to be.

It is noteworthy the various identities illustrated above were mainly derived from the participants' interactions with their school mentors during the practicum. The university supervisors, on the other hand, played a limited role in the identity construction of the participants. That said, this paper does not intend to blame university supervisors for the negative field experience of the participants. As argued by many researchers (e.g., Lawson, et al., 2015), the teaching practicum is mediated by the broader and complex institutional and sociocultural context that exerts direct influence on student teachers' professional learning and identity work. Apart from the university supervisors who might be constrained by the traditional institutional boundary between the university and school (Zeichner, 2010), the examination-oriented culture and

accountability system might also affect the student teachers' practical learning and identity building by mediating their school mentors' teaching and mentoring practice. For instance, both the participants attributed the traditional teaching style of their mentors to the strong exam pressure pervading their schools. Particularly in Ming's case, given the direct link between the teacher performance and the exam results of students, the mentor might have no choice but to push students to improve their exam results through mechanical drills and strict management. When they were appointed as school mentors, the institutional demands might have also distracted them from their responsibilities of guiding student teachers in acquiring important teaching skills and knowledge. Thus although the participants needed "constant encouragement and emotional support to overcome feelings of self-doubt and create a positive image of the teacher they want to be" (Izadinia, 2015, p. 13), their mentors failed to address their learning needs. Consequently, the participants developed intense negative feelings, which inhibited their identity development (Timoštšuk & Ugaste, 2010).

Despite the constraints embedded in the practicum, the student teachers demonstrated their self-agency in critically reflecting on their field experiences (Farrell, 2008) and constructing their preferred identities (Sexton, 2008). For instance, through negotiation with her mentor, Yang tried to implement the genre-based approach to help students solve practical problems in their learning of writing. Her agentive attempt strengthened her ideal identity as a "communicative teacher" in her future work (Lasky, 2005). Ming also tried to project his prospective identity as an "agentive teacher" who would not yield to the tough reality, although he was not able to make changes in the practicum given his low status as a student teacher. Nevertheless, not only was the participants' agency confined by their mentors' teaching and management style, but it was also abated by the practicum assessment as their field experience was mainly evaluated by the mentors (Ong'ondo & Borg, 2011). Moreover, the agency of the participants was subjected to traditional Chinese values, which emphasize harmonious interpersonal relationships (avoiding conflicts) and respect for authority (Tan, 2012). Such cultural beliefs might affect the agency of the participants and positioned them as compliant followers in their learning contexts.

Overall, this study depicts a dynamic, multifaceted, and contested picture of student teachers' identity construction through their interactions with school mentors and university supervisors during their teaching practicum. The mentoring experiences of the student teachers were influenced by a wide array of personal (e.g., previous experiences and self-agency), institutional (e.g., program arrangement and the school system), and socio-cultural factors (e.g., traditional culture), which together shape and reshape who they are as language teachers in their present and future professional practice (Izadinia, 2015).

6. Implications and conclusion

In line with previous research (e.g., Lawson et al., 2015; Malderez, 2001), this study demonstrates the critical role of mentoring in the identity construction of pre-service teachers during their teaching practicum. Specifically, this study sheds light on how negative mentoring could dismantle student teachers' ideal identities and create new ought and feared identities, which impinge on their professional learning and growth. Before discussing the implications of the study, it needs to emphasize that the results of the study need to be treated with caution as they are based on a limited sample of two cases situated in the Chinese educational setting. Also, this study only focuses on the perceptions and experiences of the student teachers without accounting for the perspectives of the university supervisors and school mentors. Given their significant influence on student teachers' professional identities, future research needs to incorporate their views and explore the rationale behind their mentoring practice. Furthermore, as the study only tracks the identity formation of the participants for a limited period, the long-term impact of the negative practicum experience on their multiple identities remains to be seen, which calls for future investigation. Despite the abovementioned limitations, this research generates some useful implications for current pre-service teacher education.

First, in pre-service teacher education programs, school mentors and university supervisors need to regard mentoring as a critical responsibility in their professional work. While school mentors need to acquire knowledge about their student teachers' perceptions, needs and expectations in learning to teach, they need to consider mentoring as valuable opportunities for their own professional development so that they can involve student teachers in different types of work (e.g., student management and classroom teaching), encourage them to experiment with innovative ideas, and engage in collaboration and mutual reflections. As such, school mentors might be able to support student teachers' professional learning and create "a positive experience for them to be better prepared to resolve any possible conflicts and tensions that might arise during the practicum" (Izadinia, 2015, p. 2). However, the mentors in this study did not treat the participants as full teachers or collaborators rather as outsiders and assistants. Therefore, it might be useful for university supervisors to provide some initial training for school mentors through meetings and workshops to foster a clear understanding of their roles in the practicum and the potential benefits they can reap from mentoring (Boz & Boz, 2006). University supervisors might also need to play a more active role in the process of teaching practicum (Koerner et al., 2002). While school visits and lesson observations are facilitative in helping student teachers acquire teaching skills and enhance their reflective abilities, they might consider establishing a systematic partnership with school mentors, e.g., through joint lesson study or collaborative action research, where they can exchange their professional knowledge and expertise and create a synchrony between university-based teacher education and school teaching to support pre-service teachers' practical learning and identity development (Tsui & Law, 2007).

The study also recognizes that complex institutional and socio-cultural forces (e.g., the exam-oriented culture and accountability system) might mediate student teachers' interaction with school mentors and university supervisors with great impact on their identity construction. Although changing entrenched practices and systems in a short time would be difficult, university supervisors and school mentors might need to work collaboratively in helping student teachers develop critical reflective abilities and form a contextualized understanding of their future work contexts so that they can be better prepared to cope with the potential challenges as prospective teachers (Ong'ondo & Borg, 2011). For instance, during the practicum, school mentors can share their personal experiences and reflections with student teachers, whereas the university supervisors can engage in ongoing communication (e.g., through dialogic journals) with student teachers to hear about their stories and offer concrete suggestions and emotional support (Awaya et al., 2003); after the practicum, student teachers can be encouraged to openly discuss and critique their field experiences with the university supervisors and their peers. The post-practicum reflection could enhance student teachers' reflective abilities and self-agency and help them develop strong and robust professional identities (Sexton, 2008).

To conclude, this study contributes to our understanding of the dark side of mentoring on pre-service teachers' identity

development in teaching practicum. Future research can continue to investigate the long-term impact of mentoring on the participants' teacher identity development in their embedded school contexts. Comparative studies are also necessary to explore the positive and negative influences of mentoring in order to gain a fuller understanding of how it can be effectively utilized to facilitate the complex and challenging process of learning to teach.

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